



Building & Validating Personas

Week 1 • Day 3 • Customer-Centric Foundations

Technical Product Manager Academy



Day 3 Objectives

- Distinguish **behavioral personas** from demographic stereotypes
- Construct a persona from a mix of observed, reported, and inferred evidence
- Run a **5-question validation** interview — and notice when you're leading the witness
- Stress-test a persona against its own **Jobs to Be Done**
- Decide when AI is safe for persona drafting vs dangerous



Today's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:15	Opening	Review PR/FAQ quotes → persona inputs
09:15 – 10:30	Block 1 + Activity 1	Behavioral vs demographic
10:45 – 12:00	Block 2 + Activity 2	Build a persona from evidence
13:00 – 14:15	Block 3 + Activity 3	Validation interviews
14:30 – 16:00	Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts	JTBD stress-test + revision

Block 1 — Behavioral vs Demographic

Why most personas don't change any decisions

The Persona That Doesn't Do Anything

Marketing Mary — 38, CMO, urban, drinks lattes

Job: CMO · Age: 38 · Income: \$150k · Hobbies: yoga

Mary wants to grow her business and loves data-driven insights. She's busy and values efficiency.

What decision does this persona change? None. It describes a stock character, not a customer. You could swap Mary for any persona and build the same product.



The Persona That Does

Dispatcher who hates re-routing

Role: Lead Dispatcher, 50–200 tech HVAC co. · Tenure: 10+ yrs in trades

- **Observed:** Spends 45 min post-close reconciling tickets on paper (6 of 8 dispatchers observed)
- **Observed:** Never uses keyboard shortcuts; refuses training that runs past 20 min
- **Reported:** "Mid-day re-routes are my worst hour" (7 of 10 interviewed)
- **Inferred:** Distrusts software that "hides" truck inventory behind a click

This persona changes decisions: no training longer than 20 min, inventory visible on primary screen, re-route flow is the hero path.



Components of a Working Persona



Always include

- Role + context (company type, size, tenure)
- Observed behaviors (not beliefs)
- Goals expressed in their words
- Current workarounds and tools
- Constraints (physical, organizational, cognitive)
- Evidence tier per claim



Usually skip

- Stock photo + invented name (if it distracts)
- Hobbies, lifestyle, brand preferences (unless load-bearing)
- Traits written as adjectives ("busy," "tech-savvy")
- Any claim you can't tie to evidence

Activity 1 — Persona Triage

Triads • 30 minutes

Your triad gets 3 real-world personas (sanitized from actual companies). For each:

- Highlight every claim that's behavioral vs demographic vs adjectival
- Mark which claims would change a product decision
- Rewrite the weakest one in 10 minutes

 5 min read • 15 min mark up • 10 min rewrite

Block 2 — Build From Evidence

The Persona Validation Canvas



The Canvas (one sheet, six boxes)

Box	Content	Evidence tiers allowed
Role & context	Who they are and where they work	Observed, Reported
Goals (in their words)	What they're trying to accomplish	Reported primarily
Current behavior	What they do today	Observed primarily
Constraints	What limits them	Observed or Reported
Pain points	What hurts (verbs, not categories)	Observed or Reported
Assumptions to validate	What you don't know yet	Inferred + AI-generated

Rule: AI-generated claims can seed Boxes 1–5 but must move to a higher tier before Friday's readout.



Using AI Safely for Persona Drafting

Role: Research assistant helping a TPM build an evidence-grounded persona.

Context:

- The user role is Lead Dispatcher at a 50-200 tech HVAC company.
- Observed behaviors (tier: Observed): [paste notes from ride-along]
- Reported statements (tier: Reported): [paste 6 interview quotes]

Constraints:

- Do NOT invent behaviors or quotes.
- Every claim in your output must cite one of the notes or quotes above, OR be flagged as Inferred.
- If you generate any claim not grounded in the inputs, tag it AI-generated with a note: "validate before use."

Format: Persona Validation Canvas (6 sections).

Activity 2 — Build Your Persona

Triads • 45 minutes

Your triad has PR/FAQ customer quote + whatever assumptions you're carrying. Build a canvas-format persona for the primary customer in your product idea.

- Start with what you actually know (provided research packet for FieldPulse)
- Use AI only for Boxes 5 and 6 — and tag carefully
- Circle the 3 claims you'd most want to validate with a real person



10 min plan • 25 min draft • 10 min mark validation targets

Block 3 — Validation Interviews

Getting to evidence without leading the witness



The Five-Question Validation Protocol

1. **Walk me through the last time you did X.** (Past behavior > hypothetical)
2. **What was hardest about that?** (Let them name the pain)
3. **What did you do to work around it?** (Workarounds reveal severity)
4. **How often does that happen?** (Frequency calibrates impact)
5. **If you could wave a wand, what would change?** (Only at the end, and discount heavily)

Do not ask: "Would you use a product that did X?" The answer is always yes. Observe past behavior instead.



Bias Traps in the Room

Bias	What it sounds like	Correction
Leading question	"Wouldn't it be great if...?"	Rephrase to past-tense behavior
Confirmation	Only listening for "yes"	Write down the 3 things that didn't fit your hypothesis
Single-story	N=1 generalized to a persona	Require 3+ interviews before claims
Enthusiasm	"They loved it!"	Count compliments vs purchase/use signals

Activity 3 — Role-Play Interviews

Triads (rotating roles) • 45 minutes

Each triad member takes a turn in all three roles: **interviewer**, **interviewee** (given a FieldPulse dispatcher character card), **observer** (tallies bias traps).

- 10 min per rotation: 7 min interview + 3 min debrief
- Observer uses a provided tally sheet (leading, confirmation, enthusiasm)
- After three rounds: which validation target did *not* survive contact?



30 min rotations · 15 min synthesize

Block 4 — JTBD Stress-Test

Does this persona explain why they'd hire (or fire) your product?



Jobs to Be Done, Briefly

A **Job to Be Done** is the progress a customer is trying to make in a particular circumstance. Products are "hired" to make that progress and "fired" when something better comes along.

Form: *"When I [circumstance], I want to [motivation], so I can [expected outcome]."*

Example: "When a tech calls out sick mid-shift, I want to re-route the remaining jobs without re-keying them, so I can keep promised ETAs without staying late."



The Stress-Test Checklist

1. For each JTBD, can the persona produce a concrete last-time-this-happened story?
2. Does the persona's current behavior explain what they "hire" today (even if it's a paper notebook)?
3. If your product didn't exist, what would they do instead? Is that a credible fallback?
4. What would have to be true for them to *fire* your product?

If the persona survives all four, you have something to engineer against. If not, you have an interview plan.

Activity 4 — JTBD Cross-Examination

Paired triads • 60 minutes • Readouts

Triads pair. Each presents their persona + 2 JTBDs. The other triad plays "skeptical engineer" and runs the stress-test checklist out loud.

- Every "I don't know" goes on a parking lot of open validation questions
- Revise the persona to downgrade or remove unsupported claims
- 60-second readout: one claim we upgraded, one we had to drop

 25 min per direction • 10 min full-room readouts

Day 3 Wrap

What we built

- An evidence-tagged persona per triad
- A validation interview protocol we can rerun anytime
- A JTBD-based stress-test for personas

What opens tomorrow

- **Pain points** — we take the persona's "pains" box and turn it into a ranked, scored map
- Your validated persona is the input

Bring to Day 4: Your persona sheet + at least 5 candidate pain points extracted from it.

Questions & Reflection

What's the one assumption you're leaving the day without having validated?